made the Buddha—a figure familiar to, and respected by, many Westerners—a part of the Hindu faith. Hinduism had survived in even more sophisticated and cosmopolitan a form, and it would see off the threat of colonial modernity as well.

And yet, curiously enough, the nature and content of the Vedanta tradition meant that while it enabled Hindus to stand up with self-confidence against imperial rule, it did not generate a narrow Hindu nationalism. If Hinduism, as Advaita Vedanta taught, was an inclusive faith, the nationalism it animated must also be inclusive. Hindus thus agitated against colonial oppression, but they were happy to pursue the goal of *swaraj* or self-rule through collective action with other Indian religious communities.

MAHATMA GANDHI

The leader who most embodied this approach was Mahatma Gandhi, who called himself a follower of Advaita Vedanta. Swami Vivekananda had preached Advaita Vedanta as an inclusive universal religion; similarly Gandhi did not conceal his own staunch Hinduism, but presented it as a faith that respected and embraced all other faiths. He was immersed in Hindu beliefs and customs, and profoundly influenced by the Yamas of Adi Shankara, particularly *ahimsa* and *satya* to which he gave profound meaning when he applied them to the nationalist cause. But when Gandhi held prayer-meetings at which Hindu devotional bhajan*s* were chanted, so also were songs, hymns and verses sacred to other religions. He actively promoted syncretism: *Raghupathi Raghava Raja Ram*, he chanted, *Ishwara Allah Tero naam*. This practice emerged from his Vedantic belief in the unity of God and all human beings; he believed staunchly that all beings have the same *atman* and therefore should be treated with equality. His conviction that all paths to God should be seen as equally valid led him to respect the beliefs and practices of other faiths and to refuse to impose his own upon them (as he explained when refusing to advocate a ban on cow slaughter that would affect other communities).

Such behaviour did not endear him to every Hindu. Gandhi's assassin, Nathuram Godse, denounced 'Gandhi's betrayal of Hinduism' during his